(IBGs). The new idea being implemented is the carving out of three IBGs from the 17 “mountain” Corps, with each IBG composed of 5000 troops and equipped with light artillery and heavy lift helicopters that are being inducted.[102] For its part, the Indian Air Force has repositioned its frontline Sukhoi-30 aircraft to the eastern sector and is expected to position a squadron of the new Rafale aircraft, as well as heavy lift and advanced combat helicopters, in its Eastern Command area of responsibility. It is also fortifying and upgrading its air bases and advanced landing grounds in that sector, as well as in the Western sector.[103]

Finally, India has made concerted efforts since the 1990s to acquire nuclear weapons and develop longer-range ballistic missiles as a deterrent against China. The land-based Agni 4 and 5 medium-range ballistic missiles have undergone multiple tests with ranges in excess of 3500 km and 5200 km, respectively, and are being inducted into the Strategic Forces Command. In addition, India is developing the K-4 submarine-launched ballistic missile, which is expected to have a range of some 3500 km. India’s nuclear strategy vis-à-vis China is aimed at acquiring an assured capability to retaliate against countervalue targets and thus achieve stable nuclear deterrence. There are claims that India is developing multiple independently targetable re-entry vehicles (MIRVs), driven by the calculation that these would provide “sufficient throw weight with which to retaliate against China” if the latter develops the capability to target India’s land-based ballistic missiles.[104]

Emerging external balancing: towards a new phase in India’s China policy?